

MINDFUL SHAPES YOGA



KLESHA: THE CAUSES OF SUFFERING IN YOGA PHILOSOPHY

In Yoga philosophy, particularly as outlined in the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali, the term Klesha (Sanskrit: क्लेश) refers to the root causes or afflictions that lead to human suffering and bind us to the cycle of samsara (the cycle of birth, death, and rebirth). Kleshas are mental states or emotional imbalances that cloud our awareness and prevent us from experiencing our true nature, which is pure, eternal, and free.

The Yoga Sutras describe five primary Kleshas, and understanding them is crucial for anyone on the yogic path, as they help us identify the sources of our suffering and transform them through mindfulness, self-awareness, and practice.

The Five Kleshas

1. Avidya (Ignorance)

- **Definition:** Avidya is the root cause of all the other Kleshas. It is ignorance of our true nature, the inability to recognize that we are more than just the body and mind. It leads to a misunderstanding of reality and perpetuates attachment, aversion, and delusion.
- Example: Imagine a person who believes their true self is their physical appearance, wealth, or social status. They identify with external possessions, leading to anxiety about losing them and a false sense of identity. This ignorance (Avidya) prevents them from recognizing their deeper, unchanging essence, which is the true self (Atman).



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2. Asmita (Egoism)

- Definition: Asmita refers to the sense of "I" or the ego. It is the identification of the self with the mind, body, and sensory experiences. This ego is a distorted sense of self that creates a feeling of separation from others and from the universal consciousness.
- Example: A person who is constantly preoccupied with the question, "Who am I?" and defines themselves by their career, family role, or social identity may experience Asmita. They often feel superior or inferior to others based on these roles, creating attachment, pride, or insecurity.

3. Raga (Attachment)

- Definition: Raga refers to attachment or craving. It is the desire to cling to things, experiences, or people that bring temporary pleasure, leading to dependence on external sources of happiness. This attachment creates suffering because it is based on impermanence.

- Example: A person who has a deep attachment to material possessions, like a car or a house, may feel immense fear and anxiety if they are at risk of losing it. The attachment creates suffering because it ties their happiness to something external and impermanent.



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4. Dvesha (Aversion)

- Definition: Dvesha is the opposite of Raga. It refers to aversion or the tendency to reject things, people, or experiences that cause discomfort or displeasure. This creates a resistance to reality and creates conflict, both internally and externally.
- Example: A person may feel aversion towards certain foods, people, or situations. For example, if someone dislikes a particular type of work and avoids it at all costs, they are caught in Dvesha. This aversion can lead to stress, frustration, and missed opportunities for growth.

5. Abhinivesha (Fear of Death or Clinging to Life)

- Definition: Abhinivesha is the fear of death or the clinging to life. It is the instinctive desire to preserve life and avoid the inevitable experience of death, which is rooted in a fear of the unknown. It is the ultimate form of attachment to the physical body.



- Example: A person who is obsessed with staying young or who lives in constant fear of death is experiencing Abhinivesha. Their attachment to the physical body and the fear of death prevent them from living fully in the present moment, often leading to anxiety and stress.

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